



The Xerox Phaser 3425

The Xerox Phaser 3425 is as bulky as the Brother HL-6050DN. It has the same tray capacity of 500 sheets, 32 MB of memory upgradeable to 160 MB, and is network-ready. The input tray features a paper level indicator similar to that on the Brother HL-6050DN.

The buttons are well placed below the LCD screen. Print jobs can be paused, resumed and cancelled right from the printer. The prompt response of the printer to button actions is impressive.

One gripe we had was with the power-on button, at least in the case of the sample we received: you need to push it real hard.

The printouts from the Xerox Phaser 3425 often topped the comparison chart, and this printer was often used as a reference point for clarity—thanks to the fine 1200 x 1200 dpi resolution. It is not easy to compare printers on

the basis of the black and white copies they produce from colour graphs and images: the printer that produces the best resemblance tops the chart. In our tests—including the other mono lasers—the Xerox Phaser 3425 led the rest, and it narrowly tipped the Brother HL-6050DN in the overall performance segment.

Printing the 36.9 MB PDF document took quite some time even on the Xerox Phaser 3425, but it was faster than on the Brother HL-6050DN.

The running costs for a printer matter more than the initial printer cost. This is where the duty cycle of the toner comes in.

To sum it up, the Xerox Phaser 3425 is a very good printer, but it's expensive as running costs go.



Cost of printer: **Rs 32,250**

Cost of toner: **Rs 9,000**

Duty cycle of toner: **10,000 pages (A4)**

at 5% coverage

Rating: 4/5

there's only a two-line LCD display. An image from a digital camera cannot be previewed on a two-line dot matrix LCD screen; moreover, a file name such as "DSC0046.jpg" doesn't tell you much about the image!

The Driver Interface

The Canon LBP5200 has an interactive driver that shows the progress and status of a print job. The interface is user-friendly as well. This only somewhat makes up for the absence of the LCD.

Performance

This part of the test was a one-sided affair. Here, we tested the printers for speed and quality. Speed was assigned lesser weightage than quality. Brother needs to do something about its drivers! The Brother HL-2700 CN did not perform as badly as the HL-6050DN, but the fact is that it did take a lot of time to transfer our 36.9 MB PDF document: other printers in the test did it on an average of less than

thirty seconds.

Epson's AL-C1100 flabbergasted us with its clarity and precision in the photo printing test. And, it also clocked lesser time than its competitor. The Brother HL-2700CN's colour reproduction of a photo fell short of our expectation; and so it was nowhere near the quality delivered by the Epson AL-C1100.

The Canon LBP5200 managed to give some competition, but didn't really match up to the Epson AL-C110—which is undoubtedly the top performer, particularly in the quality comparison.

The Verdict

It was not hard to judge our winner. With an output nearly as good as the actual image on the screen, the AL-C1100 from Epson cannot be denied top spot on the podium. It did not lack in the features department, and isn't too expensive either. There was a tussle between Canon LBP5200 and Brother HL-2700CN; the latter set itself

apart in the features and price departments, but the former was much better when it came to performance—both in terms of speed and quality.

The Canon LBP5200 lacked in the features department; whereas Brother HL-2700 CN had most features we were looking for. Every buyer must consider the cost of toner—both colour and black when buying a printer because people tend to forget that there are three colour toner and one black toner in a colour laser printer.

A Parting Word

Laser printers are definitely a cheaper alternative to inkjets when you're talking about bulk printing and speeds, but the initial investment is high. Another concern is size: most laser printers are massive, particularly colour lasers. Although the size may not be as important as the features and performance, it does matter if your office is small and space is at a premium.

We might see developments in this area, and laser printers might get smaller. They'll certainly get cheaper, of course, and we hope to bring you a more wide-ranging comparison next time round. ☒

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Contact Sheet

Laser Printers

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